Conditional types 1 and 2

Goal: To form and use conditional type 1 (real, possible situations) and conditional type 2 (imaginary, unlikely situations) to talk about nature, pollution and the environment.

The idea in two lines: A conditional sentence has an if-clause (the condition) and a main clause (the result). Type 1 = if + present simple, will + verb; type 2 = if + past simple, would + verb.

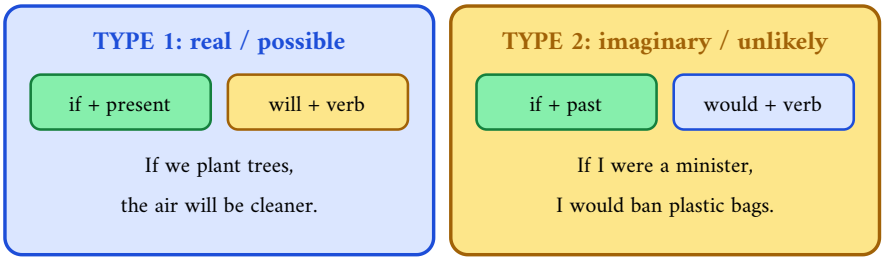


Figure 1: The two conditional patterns side by side; the tense in the if-clause tells you the type.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Structure:** if-clause + main clause. When the if-clause comes first, put a comma after it: "If it rains, we will stay home." No comma when the main clause comes first.
2. **Type 1** (if + present simple, will / can / may + base verb) talks about a real possibility in the present or future: "If people stop polluting rivers, fish will come back."
3. **Type 2** (if + past simple, would / could / might + base verb) talks about an imaginary, unreal or unlikely situation now: "If forests disappeared, many animals would die."
4. **Were** is used for all persons in formal type 2: "If I were you, I would recycle." "If I was" is heard in speech but avoid it in the exam.
5. **Never put will or would** inside the if-clause: "If it will rain" is wrong.

6. **Unless** means "if … not": "Unless we act, the planet will suffer." = "If we do not act, …"
7. **Meaning check:** the past tense in type 2 does not mean past time; it shows that the situation is imaginary.

🟢 Examples

1. Put the verb in the right form: "If we (reduce) waste, our cities (be) cleaner." **Answer:** If we reduce waste, our cities will be cleaner. **Explanation:** a real possibility, so type 1.
2. "If I (have) a garden, I (grow) vegetables." (I do not have one.) **Answer:** If I had a garden, I would grow vegetables. **Explanation:** an unreal situation now, so type 2.
3. Rewrite with "unless": "If farmers do not use less water, the lake will dry up." **Answer:** Unless farmers use less water, the lake will dry up. **Explanation:** unless already contains the negative, so the verb becomes positive.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing will or would in the **if-clause**: "If I would have money…"
- Mixing the two types: if + present with would, or if + past with will.
- Using "If I was" instead of **If I were** in formal writing.
- Keeping "not" after unless: "Unless we don't act".

🟡 Quick review

- Type 1: if + present simple → will + verb (possible).
- Type 2: if + past simple → would + verb (imaginary).
- If I were you, I would … (advice).
- No will / would after if.
- unless = if … not.